

The Letters I Still Send to Heaven



There are people who believe heaven is silent.

I don't.

I think heaven receives messages every day.

Not through envelopes.

Not through prayers whispered before sleep.

But through ordinary moments that begin with one simple thought.

"Ma, tingnan mo 'to."



Sometimes it's a movie I know you would've loved.

Sometimes it's a song that suddenly reminds me of long afternoons when life still felt simple.

Sometimes it's something funny that happened at work.

Sometimes it's nothing more than the smell of fried rice or coffee.

For a brief second...

I still instinctively think about telling you.

Then I remember.

And for just a heartbeat...

the world becomes quiet again.



People often ask whether grief gets smaller.

I don't think it does.

I think we simply become better at carrying it.

At first, I thought healing meant learning how not to cry.

Now I think healing means learning how to smile before the tears arrive.

Because now...

when I think of you...

I remember more laughter than pain.

More warmth than absence.

More life than loss.



You still appear in the smallest parts of my day.

When I cook.

When I hear a song you would've sung along with.

When I see something online and instinctively think,

"Ma, bagay sa'yo 'to."

Those thoughts don't hurt the way they used to.

They've become letters.

Tiny messages I never get to send.

Yet somehow...

I still believe they arrive.



There are moments when I wish you could see me now.

Not because I've accomplished everything.

I haven't.

Not because I've become successful.

I'm still working on that.

I simply wish you could see that I'm okay.

That I'm eating.

Sleeping.

Learning.

Laughing again.

Writing.

Living.

I spent a long time believing you would've worried about me.

Maybe that's why I keep trying to become someone you wouldn't have to.



I wonder sometimes what you'd think if you saw these pages.

You'd probably laugh at how long they are.

You'd probably tell me to stop overthinking.

You'd probably ask if I've eaten before asking about the journal.

You always had a way of making important things feel simple.

I miss that.



This journal has become something I never expected.

It began as a way to survive heartbreak.

Somewhere along the way...

it became a place where everyone I love still gets to exist.

Elaine.

Grandma.

Friends.

My future someone.

And you.

You're here too.

Not because I can't let go.

Because I don't want to erase the people who helped build me.



I used to think saying goodbye happened once.

At a funeral.

At a cemetery.

At the last embrace.

Now I know better.

Love doesn't end with goodbye.

It simply changes its address.

Mine has always been heaven.



So if there really is a mailbox somewhere beyond the clouds...

I hope these pages find you.

I hope every cup of coffee reminds you that I'm thinking of you.

I hope every song carries my voice.

I hope every ordinary day reaches you like another letter saying,

"Ma... okay na ako."

"And I hope you're proud of the man I'm still becoming."



Until we meet again...

I'll keep writing.

Love,

Your son.

— Ralph.

